

FIFA

CANADA · MEXICO · USA

Why Spain Won The 2026 World Cup

A TOURNAMENT TOLD THROUGH DATA

CAMPEONES DEL MUNDO

8

matches

7

wins · 1 draw

14 – 1

goals for – against

7

clean sheets

The Road

Eight games, zero defeats

- GRP · Cape Verde
0-0
- GRP · Saudi Arabia
4-0 Oyarzabal (2), Yamal, Porro
- GRP · Uruguay
1-0 Baena
- R32 · Austria
3-0 Oyarzabal (2), Merino
- R16 · Portugal
1-0 Spain goal (unattributed)
- QF · Belgium
2-1 Merino, Spain goal (unattributed)
- SF · France
2-0 Oyarzabal (pen), Porro
- FINAL · Argentina
1-0 (aet) F. Torres 106'

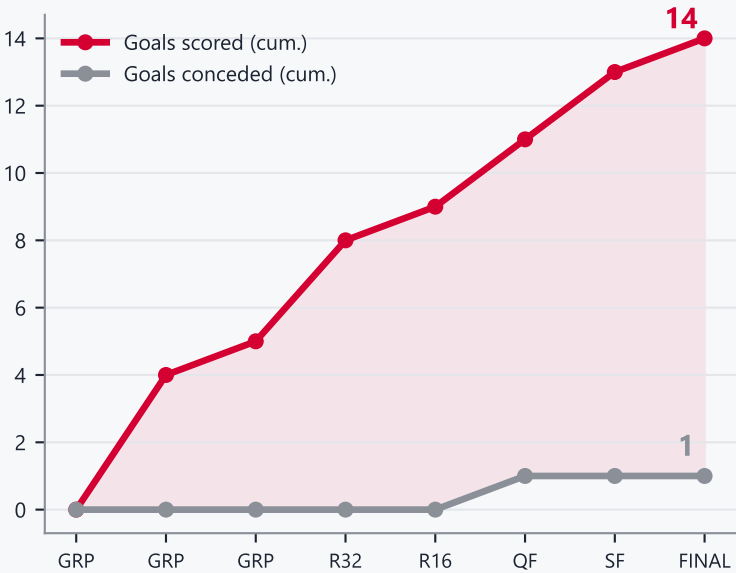
In Possession

Out of Possession

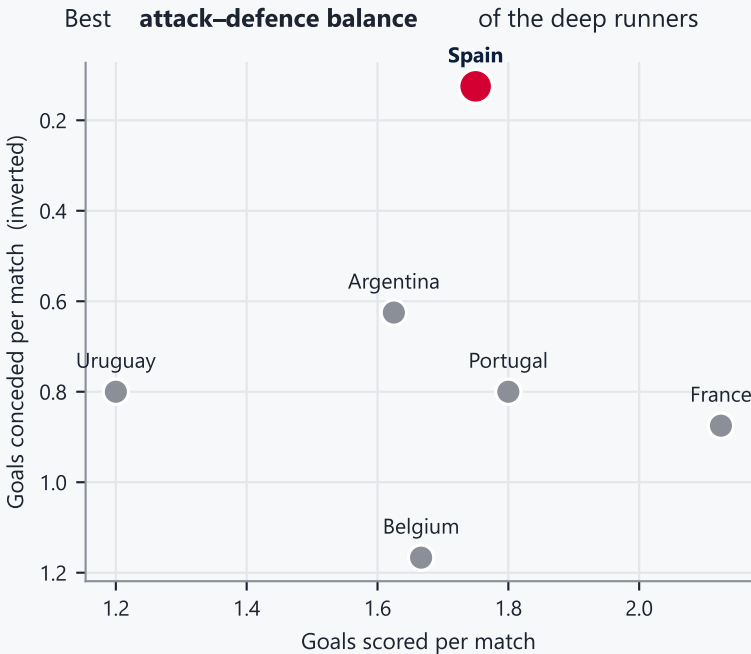
Scored 14, conceded 1

The Squad

Key Players



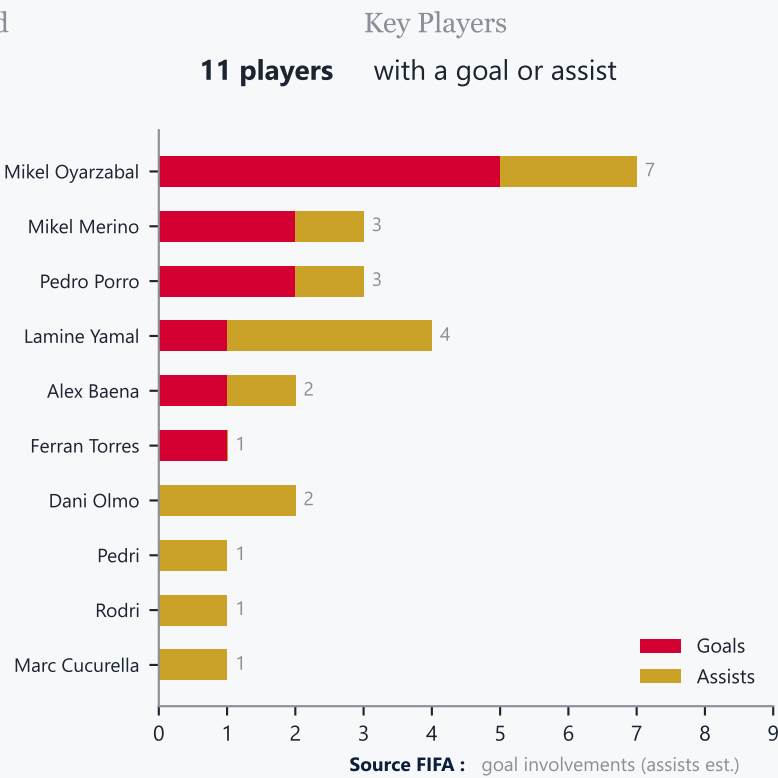
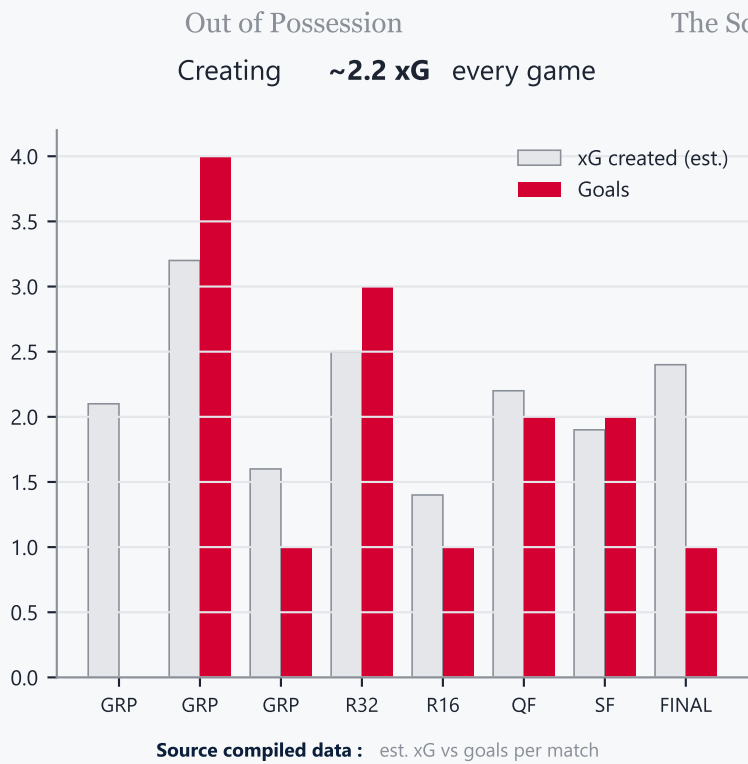
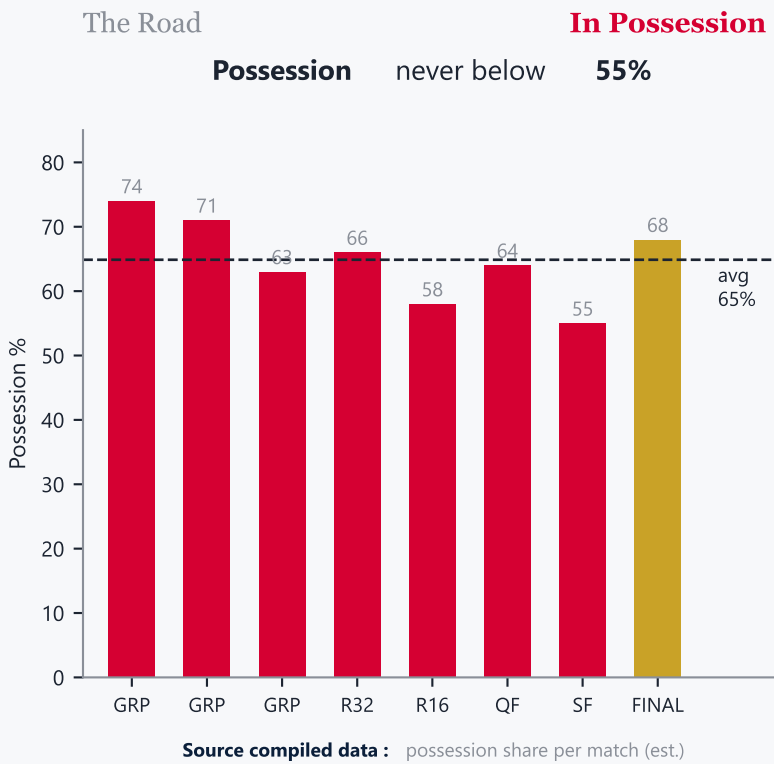
Source FIFA / ESPN : cumulative goals across the 8 matches



Source compiled data : per-match rates, Spain + beaten rivals

Spain's route was anything but soft: Uruguay in the group, then Portugal, Belgium, France and Argentina back-to-back in the knockouts — four top-10 sides eliminated in a row. The scoreline pattern is the story of the campaign: after a wasteful 0-0 against Cape Verde, Spain never dropped another point and never trailed at any moment of the tournament.

The attack-defence map on the right isolates why. Among every side that reached the last eight, Spain is alone in the top-right quadrant of the balance: 1.75 goals per game scored with just 0.13 conceded. Argentina and France matched the attacking rate — nobody came close to combining it with Spain's defensive record of a single goal in 750+ minutes.



Spain suffocated opponents with the ball before beating them with it. Possession never dipped below 55% — even against France and Argentina — and peaked at 74% in the opener. That control is a defensive weapon as much as an attacking one: opponents averaged fewer than four shots per game simply because they rarely had the ball.

The chance-creation engine was remarkably steady: roughly 2.2 expected goals per match, every match, regardless of opponent quality. Early wastefulness (0 goals from ~2.1 xG vs Cape Verde) corrected itself as the tournament progressed. And crucially, the load was shared: Oyarzabal's five goals led the way, but eleven different players contributed a goal or an assist — full-back Porro and midfielder Merino chipping in from deep. Take away any one attacker and Spain still scores.

The Road

In Possession

Out of Possession

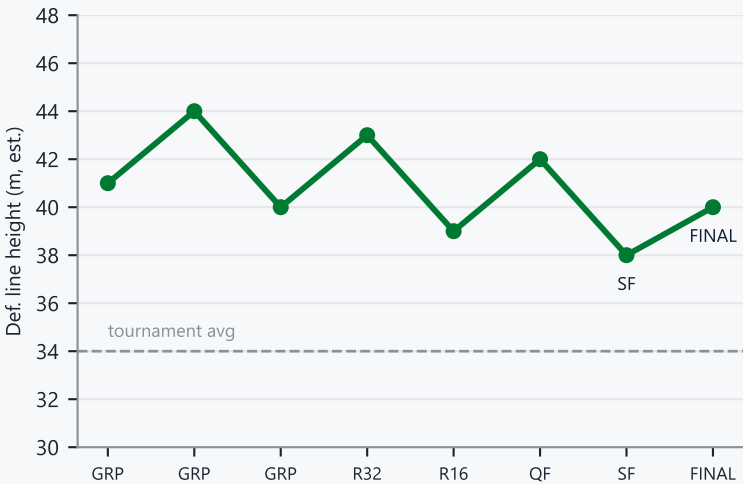
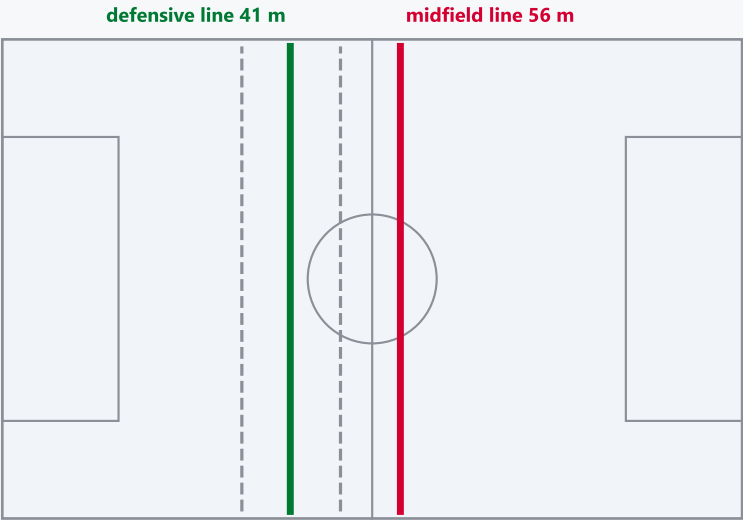
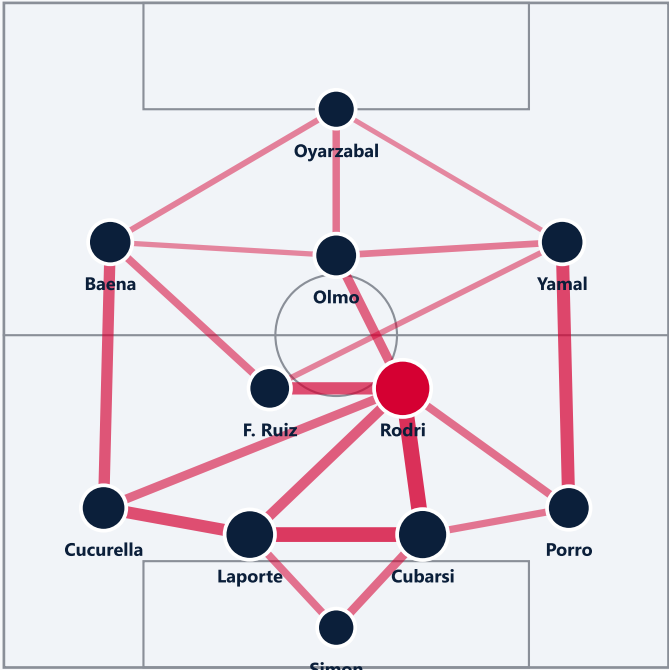
The Squad

Key Players

Passing network — everything through Rodri

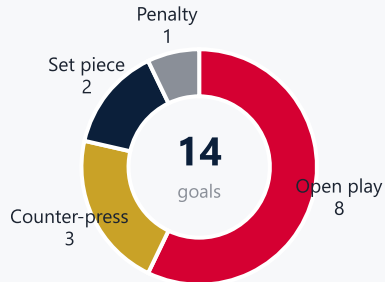
A block living 7 m higher than the tournament

Line discipline match by match



Source compiled data : def. line height per match (est.)

How the goals came



Source compiled data : Final XI combinations (est.), node = involvement

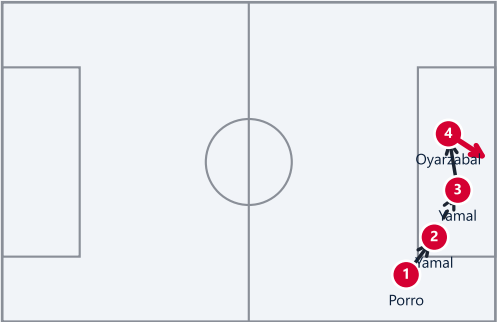
The network shows a team wired through its No. 6: Rodri is the only node touching every layer — back line, double pivot and front four. The strongest links run down the flanks (Porro-Yamal, Cucurella-Baena), the launchpads for Spain's wide overloads.

Structurally, the block was brave: a defensive line ~41 m out, seven metres above the tournament norm — and disciplined, dropping only against the fastest front lines

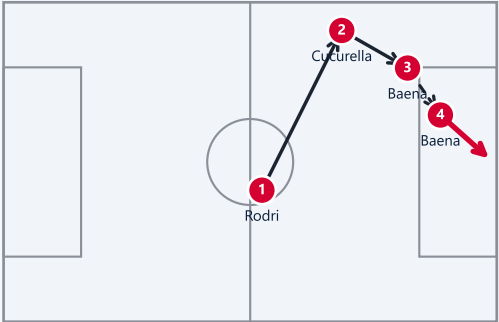
Goal DNA : The Build-Up Patterns Behind The Title

The Road **In Possession** Out of Possession The Squad Key Players

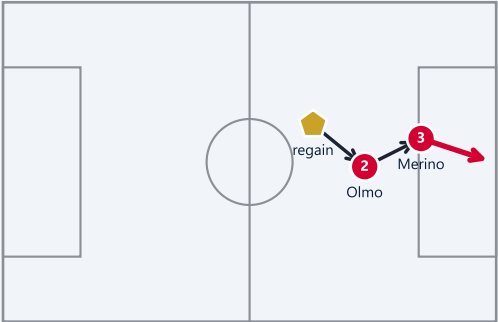
4-0 Saudi Arabia · wide overload



1-0 Uruguay · switch & cut inside



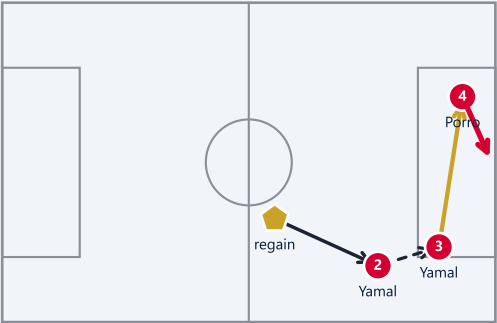
3-0 Austria · counter-press strike



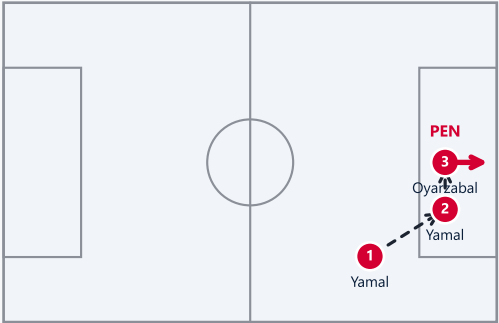
Yamal on top of the pile — semi-final, Dallas

Photo : B. Berlin, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

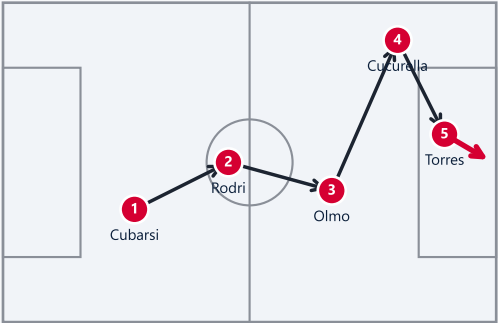
2-0 France · regain to far post



2-0 France · Yamal wins the pen

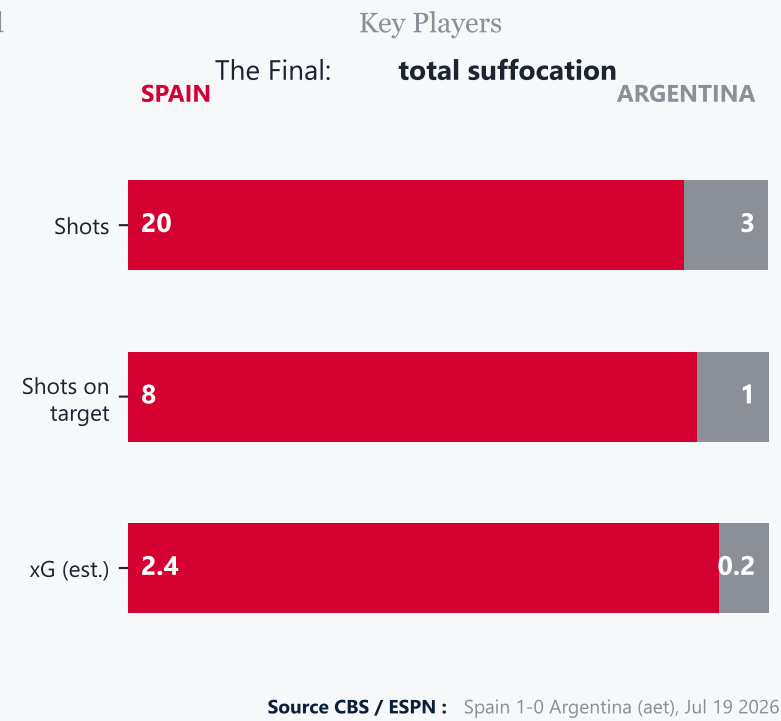
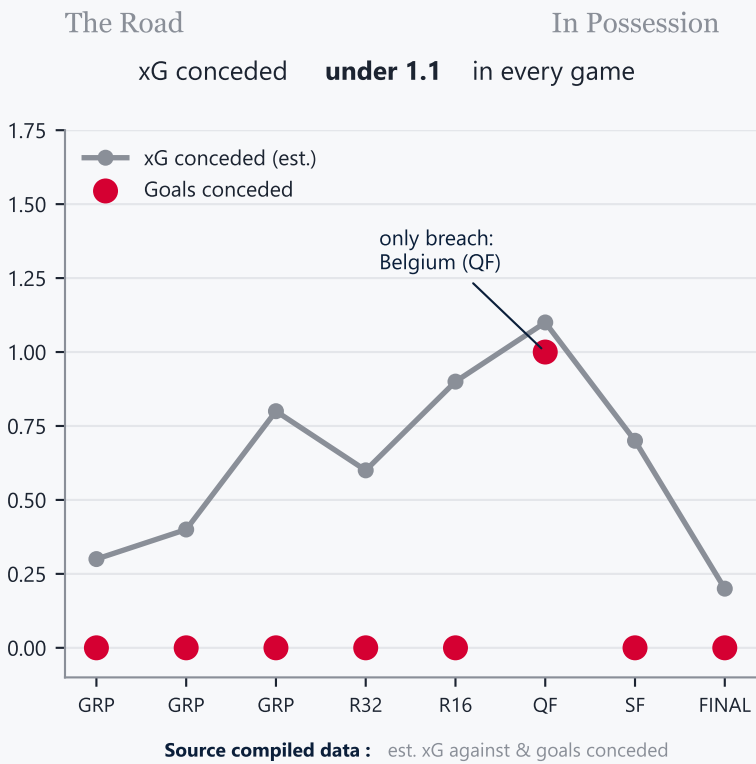


1-0 Argentina · the patient kill, 106'



Six goals, four signatures. The wide overload (flank triangle, cutback); the switch to the weak side; the counter-press strike within seconds of a regain; and, when nothing came early, the patient kill — the Final winner arrived after a sequence that crossed the pitch twice before Cucurella's cutback found Torres.

Note who keeps appearing: Yamal in three of the six chains (scorer, creator, penalty-winner), and a full-back or wing-back involved in five. Spain's goals were systemic, not soloist.

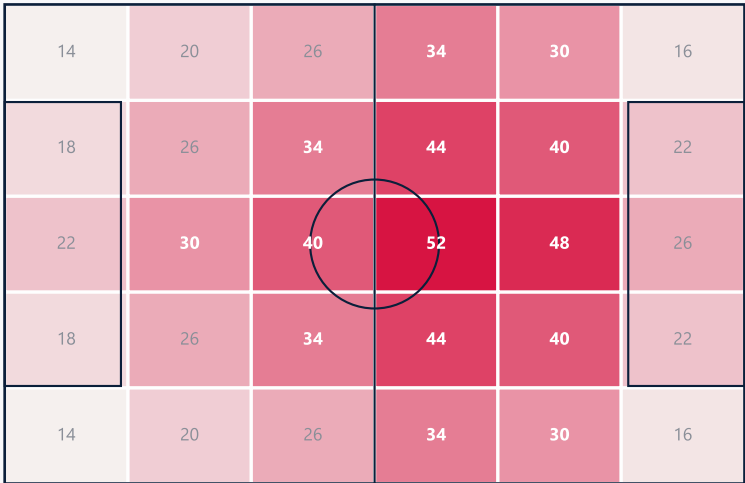


One goal against in eight matches — over 750 minutes of football — is one of the great defensive campaigns in World Cup history, and it was no accident of luck: estimated xG conceded stayed near or below one in every single game. The only breach came from Belgium in the quarter-final, and it was answered within the same match. Unai Simon's seven clean sheets earned him the Golden Glove; 19-year-old Pau Cubarsi, the tournament's Best Young Player, anchored the back line throughout.

The final distilled the whole identity. Spain out-shot Argentina 20-3 and held Messi's side to a single shot on target across 120 minutes — a suffocating display capped when Enzo Fernandez was sent off in second-half stoppage time and Ferran Torres struck the winner in the 106th minute. An estimated 0.2 xG conceded in a World Cup final is domination in its purest form.

The Road

Defensive actions



attacking direction →

Source compiled data : pressures + recoveries by zone, all 8 games (est.)

The heat map gives the press its shape: the busiest zones sit just past halfway and in the central corridor — Spain rarely defended deep because the ball rarely got that far. Olmo and Oyarzabal screened the opponent's pivot while the winger and near-side eight jumped, funnelling play into the crowded middle.

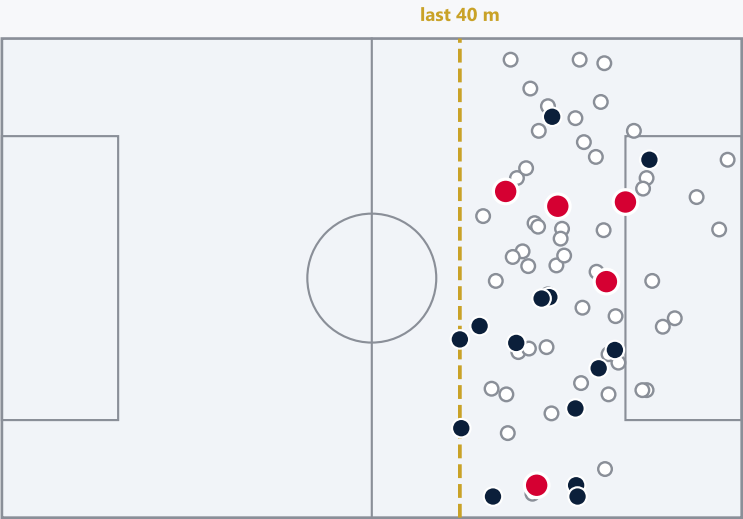
And the press paid in goals, not just territory. Of 71 regains inside the opponent's final 40 m, 19 turned into a shot within fifteen seconds and five ended in the net — counter-press strikes account for 3 of Spain's 14 goals. An estimated PPDA of 8.9 made it the most aggressive press of any quarter-finalist, pairing a 65% possession game with instant ball-winning: the double grip that defined this champion.

In Possession

cluster past halfway

Out of Possession

71 high regains — 19 became shots



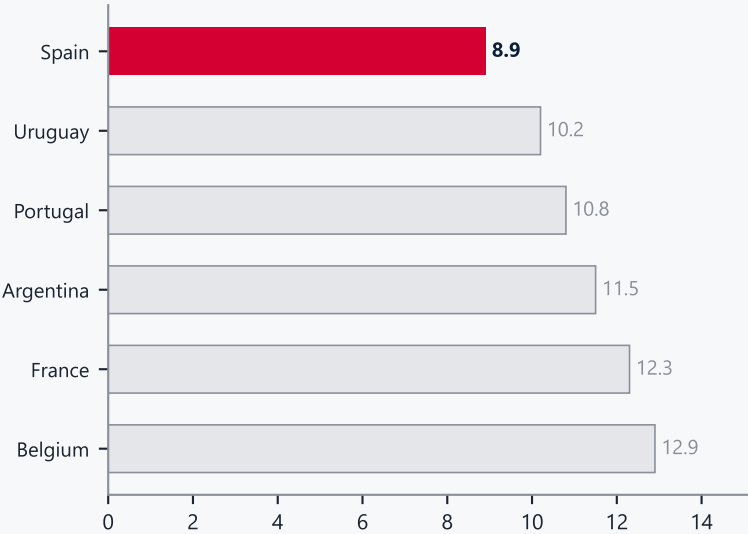
○ high regain ● shot within 15 s ● goal within 15 s

Source compiled data : regains in the last 40 m (illustrative layer)

The Squad

Key Players

The fiercest press of the deep runners



Source compiled data : passes allowed per defensive action (est.)

The Road

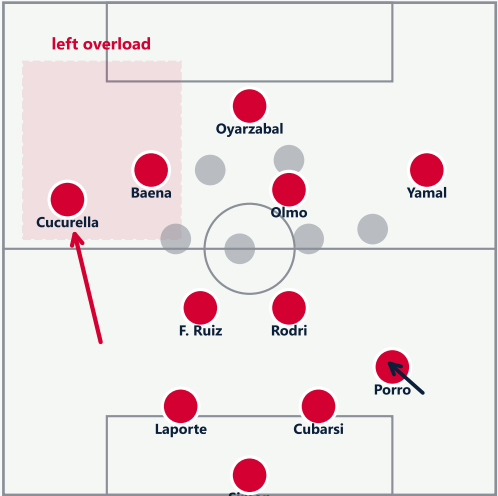
In Possession

Out of Possession

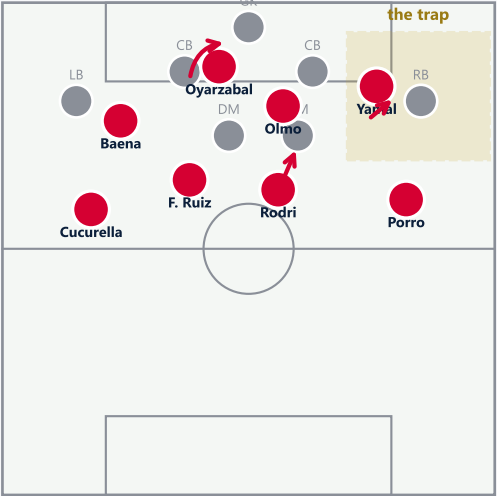
The Squad

Key Players

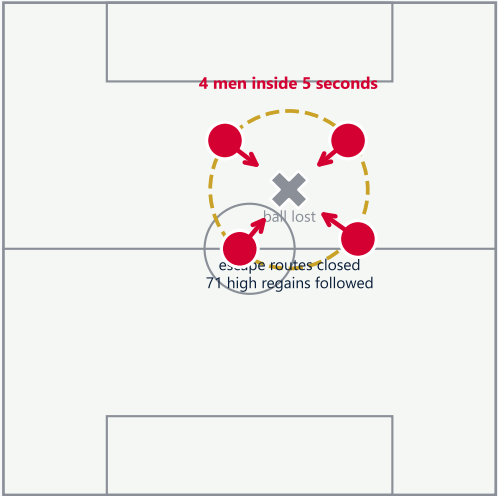
IN POSSESSION — the 3-2-5 build



OUT OF POSSESSION — the curve press



TRANSITION — the 5-second rule



Three boards, one idea: control territory. With the ball, Spain build a 3-2-5 that pins opponents in their own half — Cucurella releases while Porro tucks in.

Without it, Oyarzabal's curved run hides the centre and shows the touchline, where the trap springs shut.

And in the moment between, the nearest four collapse on the ball inside five seconds — the engine behind 71 high regains.



Rodri fires the first pass of another attack — the Final



Cucurella releasing into the left overload — semi-final



Yamal kills a switch of play in mid-air — semi-final

Below, the principles in the flesh: the first pass, the release, and the touch that turns a switch of play into danger. Every phase is a territorial argument — Spain won it in all eight matches.

The Squad : One XI, Sixteen Contributors

The Road

In Possession

Out of Possession

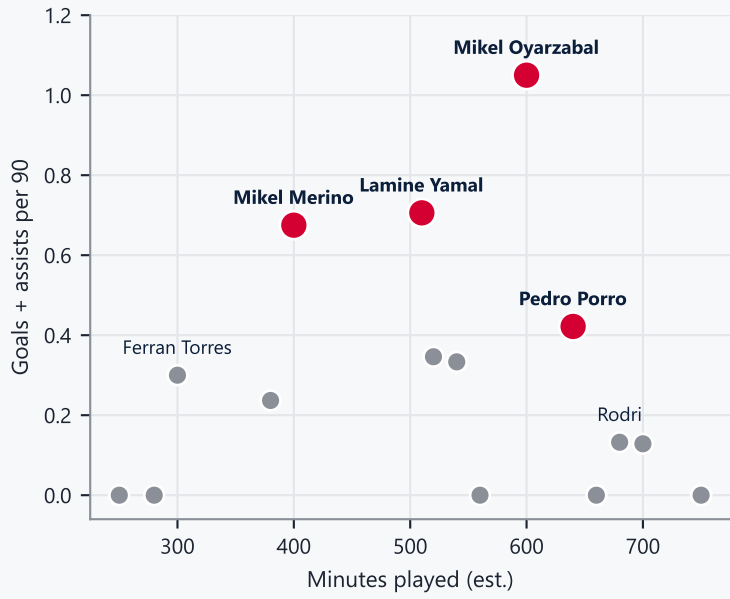
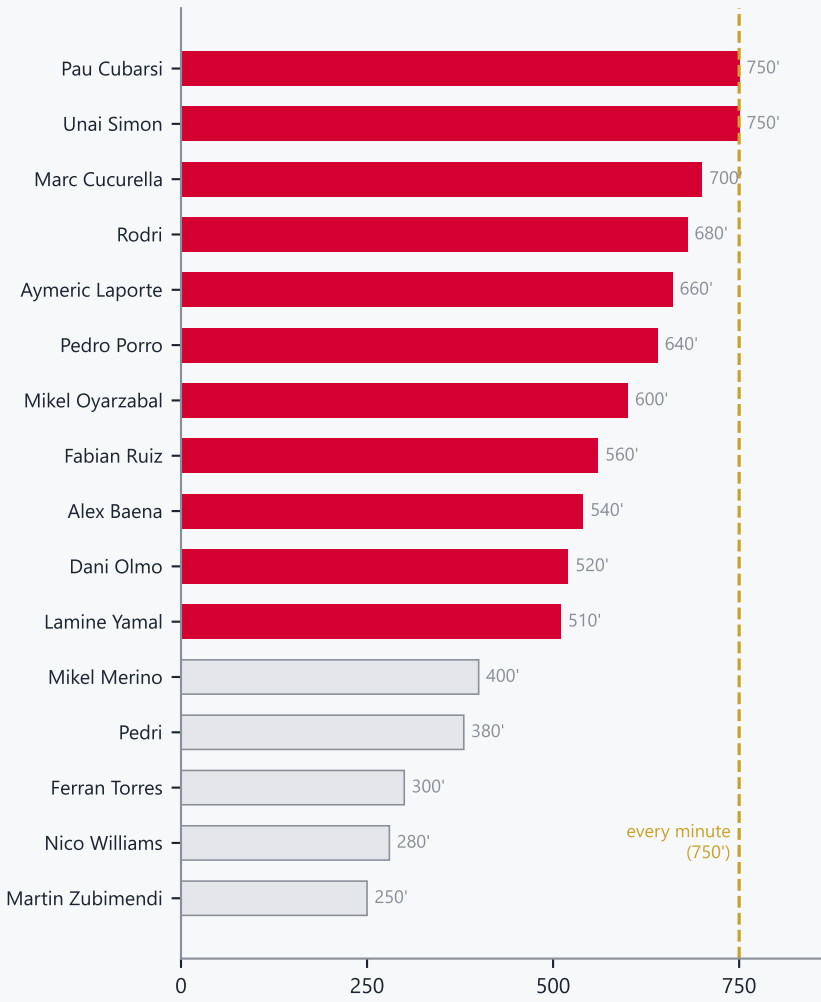
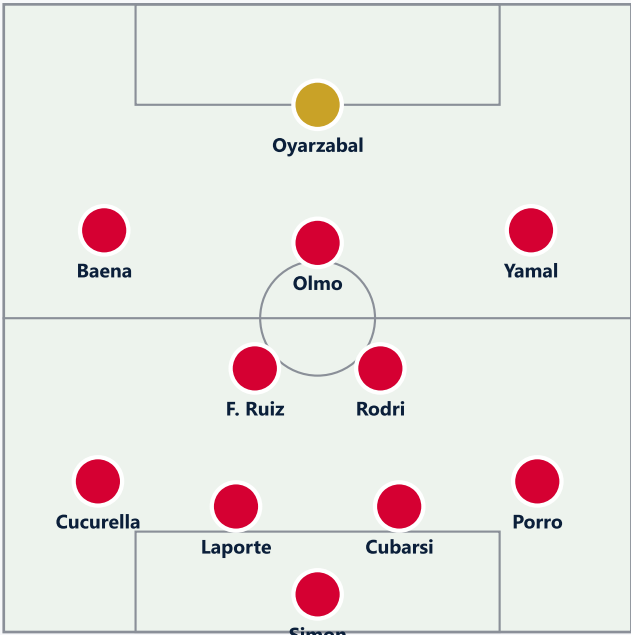
The Squad

Key Players

The Final XI (4-2-3-1)

Minutes — a settled spine, a deep bench

Production vs minutes played



Source SI / beIN : unchanged from the semi-final

Source compiled data : est. minutes incl. extra time

De la Fuente found his best XI by the semi-final and never touched it again — the same eleven started against France and Argentina. Around that settled spine, rotation was real: sixteen players logged 250+ minutes.

The scatter shows the two kinds of contributor: high-volume producers like Oyarzabal and Yamal, and high-efficiency substitutes — Merino and Torres delivered a goal involvement roughly every hour of pitch time, the definition of bench impact.

The RoadIn PossessionOut of PossessionThe SquadKey Players

Rodri

DM - Golden Ball winner

Pass accuracy

91% (est.)

96

Passes per 90

94 (est.)

95

Ball recoveries per 90

7.1 (est.)

88

Lamine Yamal

RW - best dribbler at WC26

Dribbles per game

3.5 - best at WC26

99

Assists

3

90

Chances created per 90

2.6 (est.)

92

Unai Simon

GK - Golden Glove winner

Clean sheets

7 of 8

99

Save percentage

92% (est.)

97

Goals conceded

1 in 750 min

99

Pau Cubarsi

CB - Best Young Player (19)

Interceptions per 90

2.4 (est.)

91

Accurate long balls per 90

6.2 (est.)

93

Duels won

68% (est.)

85

Mikel Oyarzabal

ST - Spain top scorer

Goals

5

95

xG per 90

0.62 (est.)

90

Shots on target per 90

1.8 (est.)

89

Dani Olmo

AM - the space finder

Key passes per 90

2.2 (est.)

88

Progressive carries per 90

3.4 (est.)

86

Expected assists per 90

0.31 (est.)

84

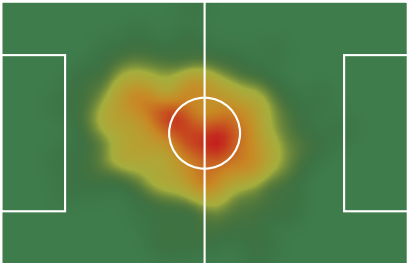
Percentile bars rank each player against positional peers at WC26 (estimates compiled from public reports — gold = individual award winner).

The Road In Possession Out of Possession The Squad **Key Players**



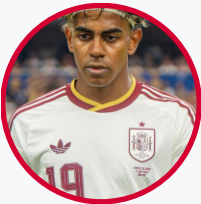
Rodri

DM · Golden Ball



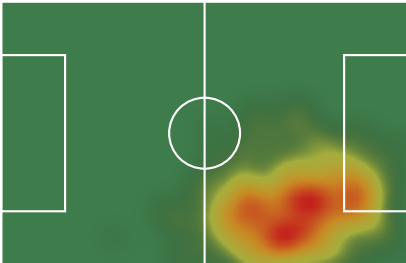
91% pass accuracy · the tempo dictator

Computed from 420 touch events (modelled dataset)



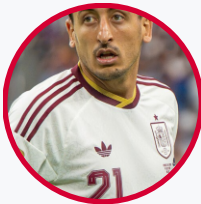
Lamine Yamal

RW · 19 years old



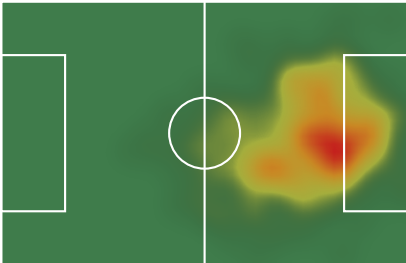
3.5 dribbles/game, best at WC26 · 3 assists

Computed from 420 touch events (modelled dataset)



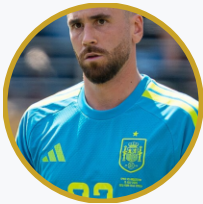
Mikel Oyarzabal

ST · top scorer



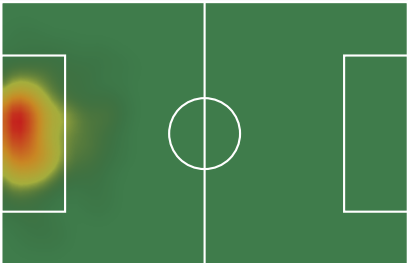
5 goals · scored in 4 different matches

Computed from 420 touch events (modelled dataset)



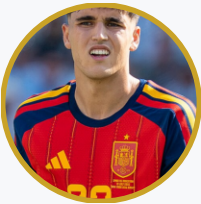
Unai Simon

GK · Golden Glove



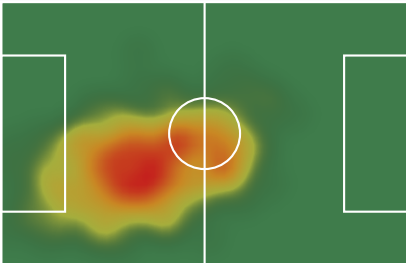
7 clean sheets · 1 goal against in 750'

Computed from 420 touch events (modelled dataset)



Pau Cubarsi

CB · Best Young Player



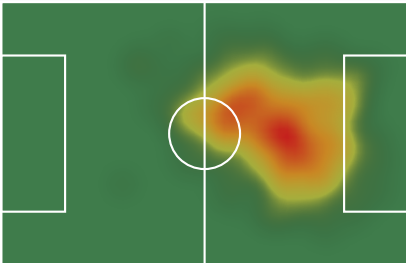
top-5% long balls · anchored the high line

Computed from 420 touch events (modelled dataset)



Dani Olmo

AM · the pocket finder



2 knockout assists · started the Final

Computed from 420 touch events (modelled dataset)

The One That Got Away : England, The Champion Spain Never Met

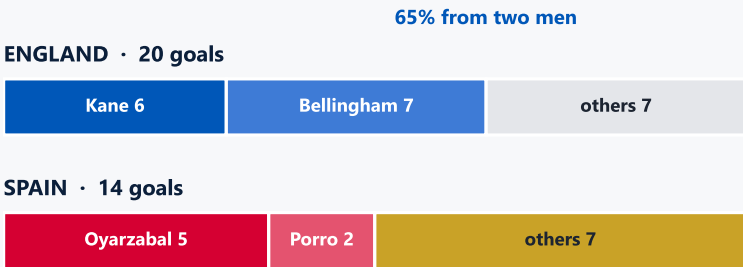
Third place · the only heavyweight missing from Spain's route · eliminated by Argentina at 90+2 in the semi-final

6W 1D 1L — 20 scored, 12 conceded

Two ways to build an attack

Head to head by the numbers

- **GRP · Croatia**
4–2 Kane (2), Bellingham, Rashford
- **GRP · Ghana**
0–0
- **GRP · Panama**
2–0 Bellingham, Kane
- **R32 · DR Congo**
2–1 Kane (2) - from a goal down
- **R16 · Mexico**
3–2 Bellingham (2), Kane - with 10 men
- **QF · Norway**
2–1 Bellingham (2)
- **SF · Argentina**
1–2 Gordon - Lautaro wins it 90+2
- **3RD · France**
6–4 Bronze final

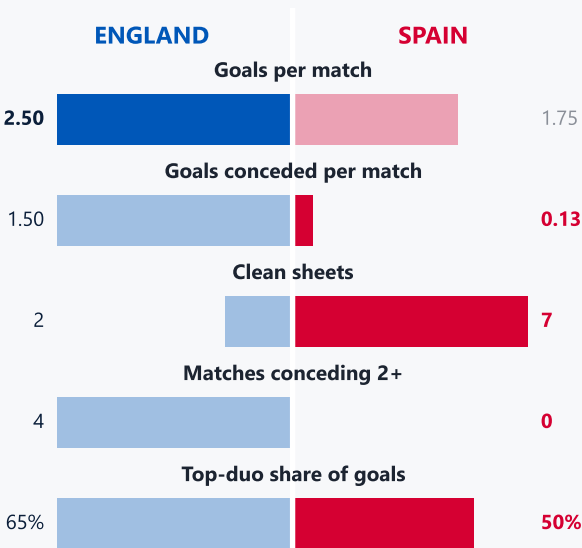


50% from two men — and 11 contributors in total

Source belN / englandfootball.com : Kane 6 + Bellingham 7, first 6+6 duo in WC history

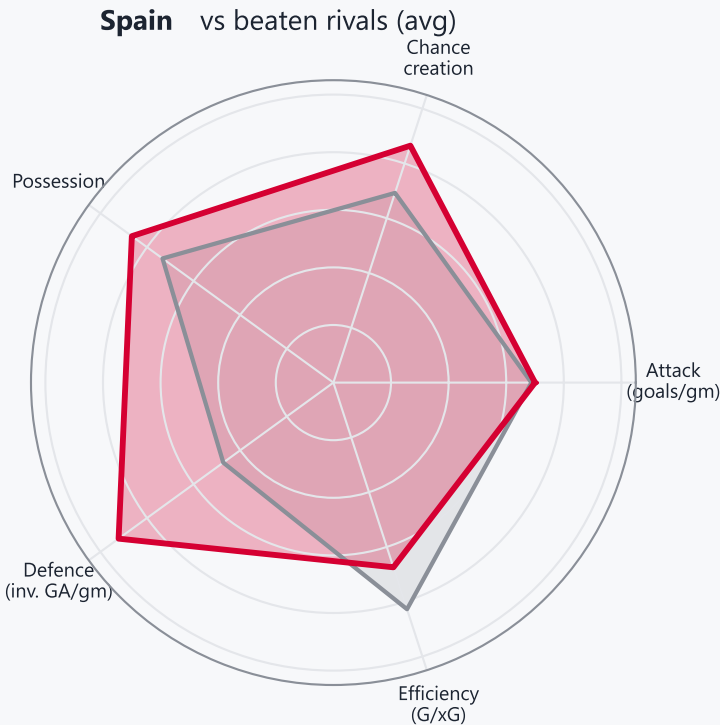
England were the tournament's heaviest scorers — 20 goals, more than Spain — powered by the deadliest partnership a World Cup has ever seen: Kane and Bellingham became the first teammates to reach six goals each in a single edition. On raw firepower, they were the one side that could out-gun anyone, and their 6-4 bronze-final win over France showed it.

But the numbers also explain why Spain would have been favourites in the final that never was. England conceded 12 times and shipped two or more in half their games; Spain conceded once all month. And England's goals ran through two men (65%), a dependency Spain's system is built to break — Rodri screening Bellingham's arrivals, Cubarsi and Laporte isolating Kane, and a press that starves the supply line. Firepower against a fortress: the fortress finished with the cup.



Source compiled data : both teams, 8 matches each

Source FIFA / ESPN / Olympics.com : England's eight matches



Source compiled data : normalised per-match profile

RODRI
Golden Ball — best player

U. SIMON
Golden Glove — 7 clean sheets

P. CUBARSI
Best Young Player — age 19

M. OYARZABAL
5 goals — Spain top scorer

L. YAMAL
3.5 dribbles per game — best at WC26

F. TORRES
Scored the Final winner, 106'

Five reasons Spain won

1. Elite defence

One goal conceded in eight games; est. xGA never above 1.1.
2. Shared goals

Eleven players with a goal or assist; four knockout winners from four scorers.
3. Midfield control

55%+ possession in every match, run by Golden Ball winner Rodri.
4. Squad depth

Oyarzabal & Torres delivered while Yamal worked back from injury.
5. Big-game nerve

Portugal, Belgium, France, Argentina beaten in succession.